

Practice Paper 36 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Significance of the polished shoes

1 mark for identifying that the father treats the day as **important** / **ceremonial**; **1 mark** for the contrast that he had not polished them even for weddings, showing voting matters to him **more than ordinary celebrations**.

Sample answer: The polished shoes show that the father regards voting as a **solemn, important occasion**, more deserving of effort than even family weddings — it underlines the **seriousness** with which he treats civic duty.

Q2. [1] — Careful preparation

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- He laid out the identity card on the kitchen table **the night before**.
- He placed the polling card beside it, with the name printed in “unfussy black letters”.
- He woke the narrator “earlier than he needed to”.
- He polished his shoes.

Q3. [2] — “Dissolve into the boy I had been”

1 mark — The father sees his son both as **a grown man old enough to vote** and yet **still as a child** in his memory.

1 mark — The word **dissolve** suggests the father fears the **adult version of his son is fragile / not yet fully formed**, and that the boy he once knew might return at any moment — it reveals the father’s **tenderness and disbelief** at how grown his son has become.

Q4. [2] — The funeral story

1 mark — The father treats voting as a **duty so important** that even **grief and family obligations** cannot excuse him from it.

1 mark — The line “the dead would forgive him and the country would not” shows that he regards his obligation to the nation as **binding** — voting is not optional but **sacred**.

Q5. [2] — From rolling eyes to listening

1 mark — In the past, the narrator was **dismissive / impatient** with his father’s stories, treating them as repetitive and over-told.

1 mark — Now, on the morning of his own first vote, he **understands them properly** for the first time and treats them with **respect** — he has begun to **see his father’s history as his own inheritance**.

Q6. [2] — Mood among the young voters

1 mark — The phrase suggests a mood of **quiet, self-conscious solemnity**: the young people are **deliberately restrained**, aware that the moment calls for adult behaviour.

1 mark — The fact that they have “agreed, without saying so” suggests a **shared, silent understanding** — the seriousness is collective and unspoken rather than imposed.

Q7. [1] — Father looking at the ground

1 mark — It reveals that the father is **anxious / nervous / emotionally moved** on his son’s behalf, even though he tries not to show it — he looks away to **hide his feelings**. (Also accept: humility / the weight of the moment.)

Q8. [3] — Atmosphere of seriousness (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the language conveys **solemnity / ceremony / quiet weight**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “smelled of floor wax and quiet effort” — the abstract noun **effort** attached to a smell makes the room feel like a place of **serious work**.
- Officials spoke in “low, measured voices, as though loud speech might disturb something fragile” — suggests an **almost religious hush**, as though something **precious** is at stake.
- The official “drew a thin red line through my name” — small, exact, almost **ritualistic** action.
- “The paper was lighter than I had expected... something so thin could carry so much weight” — the **paradox** between physical lightness and moral weight underlines the **gravity** of the act.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q9. [1] — The expected “click”

1 mark — It shows that the narrator had imagined voting would feel **dramatic or mechanical** — that such an important act ought to **announce itself**. Its quietness **surprises** him and underlines the contrast between the **outward simplicity** and **inner significance** of the act.

Q10. [2] — The nod, like learning to cycle

1 mark — The comparison links the act of voting to an earlier **milestone of growing up**, suggesting that, in the father's eyes, it is **another step into independence**.

1 mark — It is effective because it shows the father expressing **pride without words**; the gesture carries **years of shared history** in a single small movement.

Q11. [2] — Tone of the final paragraph

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, grateful, reverent, contemplative, quietly affectionate**.

1 mark — Brief justification: e.g. the narrator looks **back across the years** and recognises that what he received was not a political opinion but a **habit and a duty**, passed on through **example**.
(Reject: **sad, angry, bitter**.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Entry ticket to a queue”

1 mark for understanding that a degree **no longer guarantees a job** — it only allows the holder to **be considered** alongside others.

1 mark for explaining the **devaluation**: where a degree once led directly to good work, it is now merely the **minimum requirement** to compete with many others.

Q13. [2] — Why universities struggle

1 mark each for any two of:

- The **speed of change**: workplace skills evolve faster than universities can update courses.
- Universities take **years to design or remove a course**, making them **slow to adapt**.
- The skills employers most prize — **judgement, attention, collaboration** — are **hard to assess** through lectures, exams or essays.

Q14. [2] — Advantages of micro-credentials

1 mark for any two of (½ each, rounded up to a full mark for two clear advantages); **2 marks** for three clear advantages.

- They are **cheaper** than a degree.
- They are **faster** — weeks rather than years.
- They are **designed with employers**, so they teach directly what firms need.

Q15. [1] — The OECD finding

1 mark — Employers no longer assume a **three-year degree is automatically superior**: in several sectors they regard a **six-month bootcamp graduate** as **equally — or even more — job-ready**, showing that **employer confidence in traditional degrees is weakening**.

Q16. [2] — Bootcamp vs university (own words)

1 mark — A **bootcamp** prepares someone for the **specific tasks of the present** — the tools and methods currently in use.

1 mark — A **university**, at its best, develops the **general thinking skills** needed to handle **future problems**, including jobs that **do not yet exist**.

Reject answers that lift “do today’s work today” without rewording.

Q17. [2] — “Read what is not said”

1 mark — The phrase refers to the ability to **detect implied meaning, silence, or hidden assumption** — a kind of careful, **interpretive thinking**.

1 mark — The writer is suggesting that such a skill, though **seemingly impractical**, is in fact **deeply useful**: it trains the mind to **notice what others miss**, which matters in any serious job.

Q18. [2] — Stronger defence of the humanities

1 mark — They should **not** be defended in vague language about personal growth.

1 mark — Their **real** value is that they **reliably produce careful, flexible thinkers** — the kind of **senior leadership minds** that organisations badly need and cannot grow on their own.

Q19. [2] — Employers' share of the blame

1 mark each for any two of:

- They **advertise entry-level jobs** that demand **five years of experience** — an unreasonable contradiction.
- They have **cut their own training budgets**, then complain when new hires need training.
- They **over-rely on the degree** as a filter instead of testing for the actual skills they need.

Q20. [1] — “Restless”

1 mark — The word suggests the future of work will be **constantly changing / unsettled**, requiring workers to **re-train, switch roles or learn new skills** repeatedly across their careers.

Q21. [1] — Tone of Paragraph 7

1 mark — Any **one** of: **measured, balanced, constructive, pragmatic, cautiously optimistic**. (Reject: **angry, cynical, despairing**.)

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Why universities struggle (Paragraphs 2, 3, 5):

1. **Workplace skills change quickly**, while universities are **slow** to design or remove courses.
2. The skills employers prize most — **judgement, teamwork, attention** — are **hard to assess** by lecture or essay.
3. **Micro-credentials and bootcamps** are **cheaper, faster, and built with employers**, offering direct competition.
4. Universities themselves treat students as **passive**, test **memory rather than judgement**, and defend “useless” subjects **weakly**.

What good reform might look like (Paragraphs 6, 7):

5. Employers should **drop degree requirements** and **test directly** for needed skills.
6. Employers should **fund apprenticeships** combining **paid work and structured study**.
7. Universities should **retain serious thinking** but **build shorter, practical pathways** into their degrees.
8. **Governments** should **fund both routes**, and students should choose **combinations of degrees and short courses**, taken across a long working life.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Universities struggle to meet employer needs because workplace skills change faster than courses can be updated, and the qualities firms value most are hard to test by exam. Cheaper, faster, employer-designed bootcamps now compete directly, and universities too often reward memorisation. Good reform would see employers drop lazy degree filters, test for real skills, and fund paid

apprenticeships, while universities protect serious thinking but add shorter practical pathways, with governments supporting both and students mixing the two.

Length count: 78 words from “Universities” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —